



THE MODES OF THE HARMONIC MINOR SCALE

WHAT IS THE HARMONIC MINOR SCALE

In order to understand the modes of the Harmonic Minor Scale, you have to understand what the Harmonic Minor Scale is and where it is derived in its own right.

This scale is called harmonic minor because of its versatility in harmony building through the voicing of chords in a minor key.

In the key of A minor, the dominant (V) chord (the chord built on the 5th scale degree would be a minor triad) in the natural minor (aeolian) scale. But when you raise the 7th degree from G to G#, the triad created is substituted for a major triad (E major in this case).

This scale can be found extensively in classical music, by composers such Mozart, Beethoven & Bach to name but a few.

Because of its interval range, the Harmonic minor scale is often used to emphasize the tension in a melody, as well as to resolve them (because of the leading note).

You can see the differences between fig 1 & fig 2 over the page.

Aeolian Scale -1- 2- b3- 4- 5- b6-b7- 8

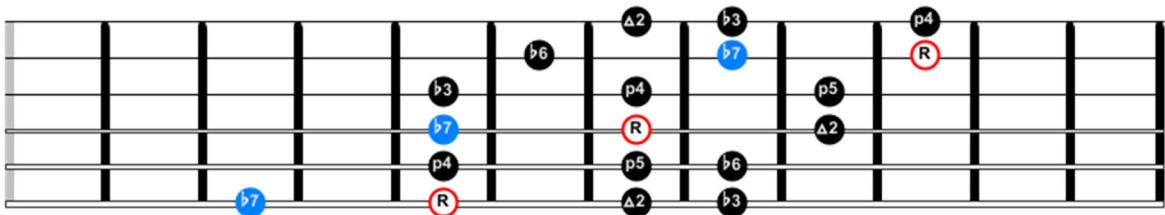


Figure 1- Aeolian Minor Scale

Harmonic Minor Scale -1- 2- b3- 4- 5- b6-#7- 8

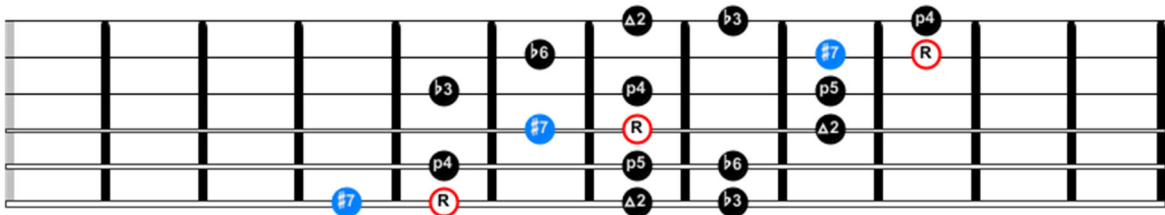


Figure 2- Harmonic Minor Scale

THE MODES OF THE HARMONIC MINOR SCALE

As with the modes of the Major Scale, so too, the Harmonic Minor Scale has its own set of modes. Starting from the different degrees within the Harmonic Minor Scale. For the purpose of simplicity, I am going to present the modes of the Harmonic Minor Scale in the key of A minor.

The modes of the **A** harmonic Minor Scale are as follows:

- 1- **A** Harmonic Minor Scale
1 – 2 – b3 – 4 – 5 – b6 – #7 – 8
- 2- **B** Locrian #6
1 – b2 – b3 – 4 – b5 – #6 – b7 – 8
- 3- **C** Ionian #5
1 – 2 – 3 – 4 – #5 – 6 – 7 – 8
- 4- **D** Dorian #4
1 – 2 – b3 – #4 – 5 – 6 – b7 – 8
- 5- **E** Phrygian Dominant (#3)
1 – b2 – #3 – 4 – 5 – b6 – b7 – 8
- 6- **F** Lydian #2
1 – #2 – 3 – #4 – 5 – 6 – 7 – 8
- 7- **G#** Super Locrian (Altered Dominant Scale)
1- b2 – b3 – b4 – b5 – b6 – bb7 – 8

Harmonic Minor #7 Scale -1- 2- b3- 4- 5- b6-#7- 8

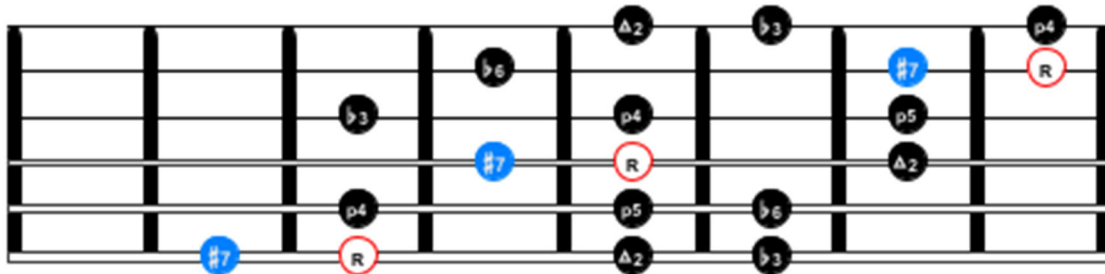


Figure 3- Harmonic Minor #7 Scale

Locrian #6 Scale -1- b2- b3- 4- 5-#6- b7- 8

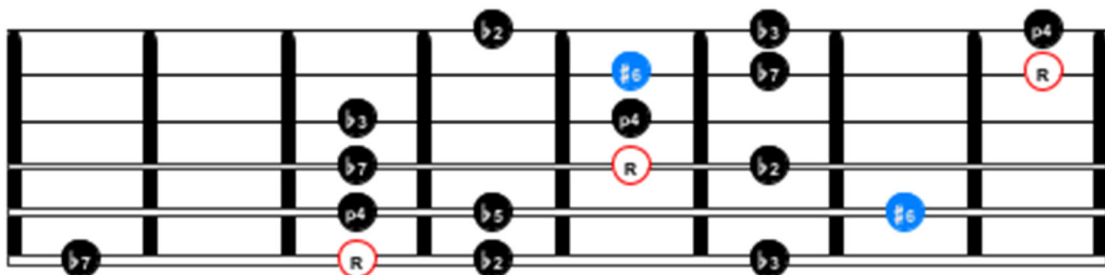


Figure 4- Locrian #6 Scale

Ionian #5 Scale -1- 2- 3- 4-#5- 6- 7- 8

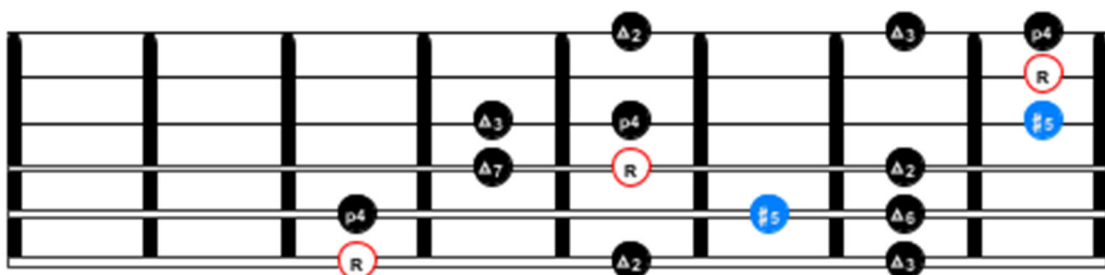


Figure 5- Ionian #5 Scale

Dorian #4 Scale - 1- 2- b3- #4- 5- 6- b7- 8

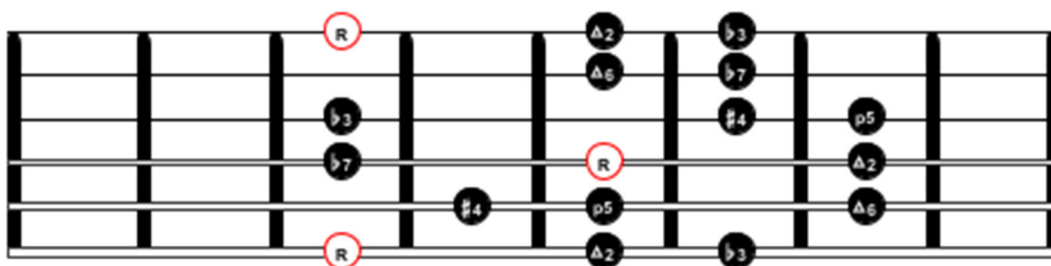


Figure 6- Dorian #4 Scale

Phrygian Dominant #3 Scale - 1- b2- #3- 4- 5- b6- b7- 8

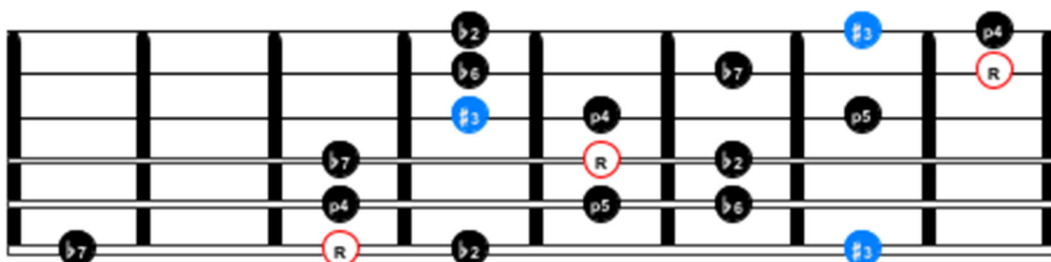


Figure 7- Phrygian Dominant #3 Scale

Lydian #2 Scale - 1- #2- 3- #4- 5- 6-7- 8

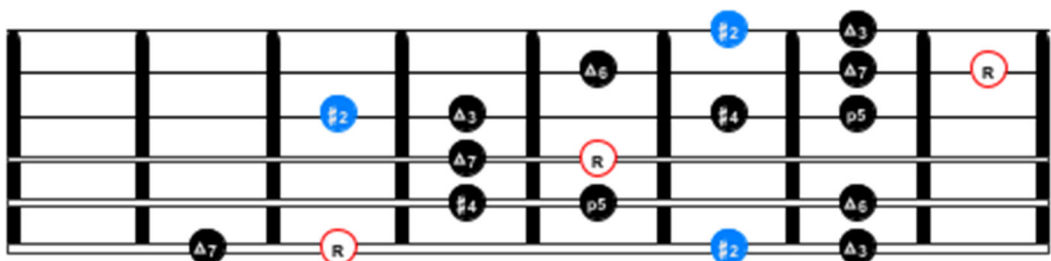


Figure 8- Lydian #2 Scale

Super Locrian Scale - 1- b2- b3- b4- b5- b6- bb7- 8

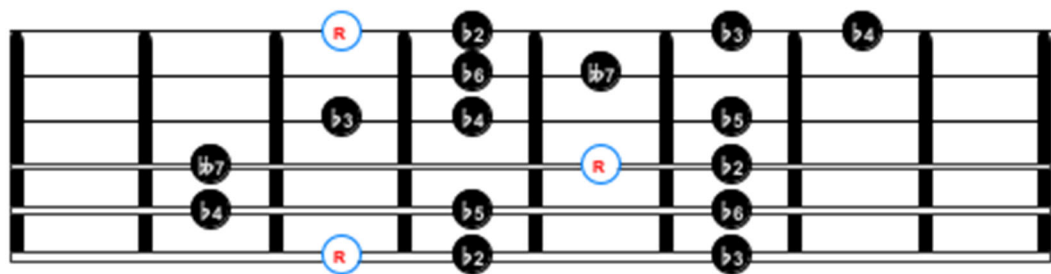


Figure 9- Super Locrian (Altered Dominant) Scale

THE CHORDS OF THE MODES OF THE HARMONIC MINOR SCALE

As we have done with the modes of the Major Scale, working out the assigned chords from the modes of the Harmonic Minor Scale can be relatively easy. See figure 10.

Below this, we are also going to build a table using 4 & 5 note chords in the key of A minor, this will allow us to incorporate the specific colour tones to better demonstrate the feeling of the desired mode fig 11.

Mode	Triad	Notes	Scale Degrees
A Harmonic minor #7	A min	A C E	1 b3 5
B Locrian #6	B dim	B D F	1 b3 b5
C Ionian #5	C aug	C E G#	1 3 #5
D Dorian #4	D min	D F A	1 b3 5
E Phrygian Dom #3	E maj	E G# B	1 #3 5
F Lydian #2	F maj	F A C	1 3 5
G# Super Locrian	G# dim	G# B D	1 b3 b5

Figure 10- Basic Triad chord table for A Harmonic minor

Mode	Triad	Notes	Scale Degrees
A Harmonic minor #7	A min/maj7	A C E G#	1 b3 5 #7
B Locrian #6	B min7/b5/#13	B D F A G#	1 b3 b5 #6
C Ionian #5	C maj7/#5	C E G#	1 3 #5 7
D Dorian #4	D dim/#11	D F G# A	1 b3 b5 #11
E Phrygian Dom #3	E dom 7	E G# B D	1 #3 5 b7
F Lydian #2	F min/maj7	F G3 C E	1 #2 5 7
G# Super Locrian	G# dim7	G# B D F	1 b3 b5 bb7

Figure 11- Extended Chords for A Harmonic Minor Modes

So there you have it. The modes and chord assignments of the Harmonic minor scale.

Make sure you practice the scales with chordal backing tracks to allow you to improvise with the said mode.